

How does ai impact the environment/waste water??

Posted by u/Mountain_Today956 • 0 points • 19 comments

I would like to start off my saying that I'm literally just here because I want to be educated on the topic. I know ai makes us lose water but, how? I tried to look it up but couldn't really find anyone properly explaining it. I get that like water is used to cool the systems and it evaporated, and (I think) that when it rains the water is then contaminated, but can that water not just be filtered? I'm just looking to be educated and in no way do I mean to defend ai.

Comments

u/Mental-Silver-3105 • 2 points • 2026-02-14 07:27 UTC

Morons push the ai water argument. Farming uses way more water. Go boycott almond farmers before ai.

u/ross_st • 3 points • 2026-02-13 09:12 UTC

It's not that the water is contaminated.

It's that when it rains back down, it won't be in the same place. The use of large volumes of water for cooling displaces more water than would otherwise be, thus causing local water shortages.

u/Miserable-Whereas910 • 0 points • 2026-02-14 06:07 UTC

Not only that, more likely than not it'll rain down in the ocean. Converting scarce fresh water into abundant salt water.

u/snek_kogae • 2 points • 2026-02-13 00:50 UTC

Not inherently through direct use but local communities are definitely impacted by the data center designs big tech are choosing to go with

Globally direct usage isn't a huge proportion despite big numbers, *however* I think the biggest threat from AI is more the bot farms, astroturfing, trolling, etc to politicians, businesses, etc that would be key to turning us around.

u/pmnBattleCityDev • 3 points • 2026-02-12 21:22 UTC

Evaporated water isn't contaminated when it rains back down. Only the water itself evaporates not the contaminants. (Just like when ocean water evaporates we don't get salt water rain, just pure water)

Also the water impact of ai is realistically just not a good argument against it. It's just something people latched onto because they want any possible argument they can add to the list. You could use chat gpt for ages and use less water than it takes to make a new pair of jeans and a shirt.

Just look up the water use for textiles or agriculture compared to data centers. Also the data centers that people talk about run everything from ai to sites like Reddit or YouTube and every business in the world that uses internet. So much of the data center water isn't even going to ai.

The simple answer to your question tho is it doesn't actually cause any water loss overall. Just like you drinking water or agriculture or textile manufacturing doesn't cause that water to be lost. It all stays as water and filters back through the water cycle.

You seem to understand this better than a lot of people based on the way you asked the question but yeah water use doesn't mean water loss. It's just being used and can be used again and again. We have been using the same water over and over again all of human history and we don't lose it. If someone is complaining about how ai is wasting all the worlds water or making us lose water then it's safe to say they have been caught up in some bad info they never bothered to check for themselves.

u/yuru2323 • 4 points • 2026-02-13 03:35 UTC

Though AI seems to require fresh water, in comparison to other industries? And many data centers are set up in areas that directly impact the shortage of water as far as I've checked.

u/Guinnesslover69 • 1 points • 2026-02-12 21:04 UTC

I think if it was easy to filter water like that, we would have done it long ago with ocean water. It's an incredibly expensive procedure and not economically feasible.

This will also make electricity more expensive, because all the water power-plants won't have enough capacity. What happens then? You have to make electricity from raw materials like oil/gas and coal, which is not good for mother earth.

We could make more nuclear power plants, but that is also something that is being pushed down by propaganda by the oil companies, because it would hurt their profits, a lot. There isn't exactly an abundance of radioactive material that is needed in a power plant either.

So in the end I think it's all about money, as always.

This is just something I pulled out of my ass, so I could be off here. I'm more than happy to be corrected.

u/NotReallyaGamer_ • 7 points • 2026-02-12 21:01 UTC

AI contaminated water with so called "forever chemicals" that are on a molecular scale equivalent or smaller than a virus, but aren't weak to disinfectants. This means they have to be either vaporized using a high power, small laser; or squeeze the water through microscopic holes in tubes that are barely large enough to fit a single water molecule. That water then has to be re-exposed to minerals to make it safe to drink.

This process takes several hours and hundreds of dollars for a couple thousand gallons of water at most

u/Paradoxe-999 • 2 points • 2026-02-13 13:11 UTC

I can't find sources about how AI is contaminating water, do you have some I could read please?

I only find ones about water consumption.

u/NotReallyaGamer_ • 0 points • 2026-02-13 22:12 UTC

Search about datacenters as a whole instead. AI runs on datacenters that also manage other processes so try to search for the broader term instead.

u/Slopadopoulos • -2 points • 2026-02-12 21:28 UTC

That's complete nonsense

u/Ok_Half_6257 • 3 points • 2026-02-13 06:43 UTC

\> calls it nonsense.

\> refuses to elaborate.

u/Which_Lie_8932 • 6 points • 2026-02-13 03:03 UTC

No, it's just simplified. The proper term is reverse-osmosis.

u/Slopadopoulos • 1 points • 2026-02-13 13:08 UTC

Water used in data centers is not contaminated with forever chemicals is what I mean.

u/Which_Lie_8932 • 1 points • 2026-02-13 13:09 UTC

Yes, it is. They get contaminated by PFAS.

u/Slopadopoulos • 1 points • 2026-02-13 13:14 UTC

AI is actually being used to address the problem of PFAS

[Advancements in artificial intelligence-based technologies for PFAS detection, monitoring, and management - ScienceDirect] (<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0048969725011775>)

u/Which_Lie_8932 • 1 points • 2026-02-13 22:38 UTC

Great, now lets only use AI's fixing issues like that one instead of AI's creating the issue.

u/Slopadopoulos • 1 points • 2026-02-13 13:11 UTC

That's a myth being spread around by antis

u/Any-Prize3748 • 2 points • 2026-02-13 17:59 UTC

Bro this is an anti sub lol.

u/Slopadopoulos

• 1 points •
2026-02-13
18:06 UTC

I know. It's possible to be wrong even on your own sub.